SOUTH DAKOTA

The Mount Rushmore State



The high prairie of southeastern South Dakota is a place that demands something of the people who settle it—endurance, resourcefulness, and a willingness to find richness in simple things. It was into this demanding landscape that thousands of Russian-German immigrants arrived in the 1870s and 1880s, fleeing the collapsed promises of Catherine the Great's land grants along the Volga River. They came with little, but they carried their food traditions with them like seeds in a coat pocket, and those traditions took root in the Dakota soil just as stubbornly as the settlers themselves.

Among those immigrants were communities of Mennonites and Lutheran Germans who settled heavily around the towns of Freeman, Menno, and Hutchinson County in the James River Valley—a broad, flat sweep of glacial prairie that reminded many of the Russian steppe they had left behind. They brought their language, their faith, their architecture, and their recipes. One of those recipes was Tschilick—small cubes of lamb or mutton, salted and skewered, cooked over an open fire. It was peasant food in the most honorable sense: portable, protein-rich, and deeply satisfying after a long day of breaking sod or bringing in wheat.

The dish had roots older than the immigrants themselves. Variations of skewered, fire-cooked meat had traveled the Silk Road for centuries, carried by nomadic peoples across Central Asia and into the Russian steppe, where the German settlers had absorbed it into their own cooking over generations of living alongside Turkic and Cossack neighbors. By the time it arrived in South Dakota, it had already crossed continents. The Dakota prairie simply gave it a permanent home.

As the railroad expanded through southeastern South Dakota in the late 19th century, small towns grew around the depots, and with them came taverns, community halls, and gathering places where Chislic—the name now anglicized and claimed—appeared as a fixture at every celebration. Lamb gave way to beef and venison as ranching and hunting shaped the local economy, and the open fire eventually became the deep fryer in many kitchens, though the spirit of the dish never changed. Tender cubes of meat, seasoned with garlic salt and served with crackers and hot sauce—unpretentious, communal, and completely addictive.

In 2018, South Dakota officially named Chislic the state's official nosh, a recognition long overdue for a dish that had quietly anchored potlucks, bar menus, and family gatherings for over a century. Order it anywhere between Sioux Falls and the Missouri River and you will understand immediately why it earned that title.

When you make this dish, you are pulling on a thread that runs from the Russian steppe to the Dakota prairie, from an open campfire to your own kitchen. The beauty of Chislic is in its honesty—good meat, good heat, and nothing in the way. One bite and you will wonder how something this straightforward became something this irresistible. Make it once, and it will not be the last time.

CHISLIC

Salted cubes of meat, fried quick and eaten hot—a thousand years of fellowship in every bite.

Yield: 4–6 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 1–2 lb. lamb, mutton, venison, or beef (sirloin/round), cut into 1-inch cubes
- Salt or seasoned salt, to taste
- Garlic powder (optional)
- Vegetable or peanut oil, for frying
- Toothpicks or skewers

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare the meat*: Cut meat into 1-inch cubes. Pat dry with paper towels and lightly salt.
2. *Frying method (traditional)*: Heat oil to 350–375°F (175–190°C) in deep fryer or cast-iron pot. Fry meat in small batches for 1–2 minutes (rare to medium doneness). Remove and drain briefly on paper towels. Optional grilled method: Skewer meat and grill over high heat, 2–3 minutes per side. Immediately season with salt, garlic powder, or Lawry's-style seasoning.
3. *To serve*: Serve hot, on toothpicks or skewers. Pair with soda crackers, hot sauce, and a cold beer or iced tea.

